busy with his RATO motor. He had arranged everything that was required before being asked. He obtained funding of Rs 75 lakhs with a further commitment towards any unforeseen costs. “You name the thing and I wil get it for you, but do not ask for time,” he said. At times, I often laughed at his impatience, and read for him these lines from T.S. Eliot’s Hol ow Men:

Between the conception

And the creation

Between the emotion

And the response

Falls the Shadow.

Defence R&D at that time was heavily dependent on imported equipment. Virtual y nothing indigenous was available. Together, we made a long shopping list and drew up an import plan. But this made me unhappy—was there no remedy or alternative? Was this nation doomed to live with screwdriver technology? Could a poor country like India afford this kind of development?

One day, while working late in the office, which was quite routine after I took up the RATO projects, I saw a young col eague, Jaya Chandra Babu going home. Babu